Chapter Three

Anarchy

Between 1120 and 1139, the Count of Anjou becomes king of Jerusalem, the Holy Roman Empress becomes Countess of Anjou, and civil war wrecks England

FOR THE LAST FIVE YEARS of his life, the Holy Roman Emperor Henry V was poised to become the most powerful monarch in the world.

Matilda, daughter of Henry I of England, had spent four years betrothed to Henry V. At thirteen she was finally sent to Mainz, where she married the twenty-eight-year-old emperor in a ceremony of "fitting splendour" (Henry of Huntingdon, writing in 1129, remarks that her father was forced to levy a special tax on the English in order to pay for it). Six years later, catastrophe struck at home. Her brother, William, a year her junior and the heir to the English throne, got drunk with friends and ordered a ship put out to sea for all of them. Steering while intoxicated was as dangerous then as it is now; William of Malmesbury says that it was "already night and pitch dark when those young hotheads, drunk as well as foolish, put out from the shore. The ship sped swifter than a feathered arrow, and . . . struck, through the carelessness of her besotted crew, a rock projecting from the surface not far from shore."[1]

Late November was not a good time to be wrecked in the English